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STIs and chlamydia screening data release (England): 2024

New data on sexually transmitted infections (STIs), and on screening for chlamydia, in England was published by the UK Health Security Agency (UKHSA) on 4 June, providing comprehensive and up-to-date information on STI diagnoses, sexual health service provision and National Chlamydia Screening Programme (NCSP) activity up to the end of 2024 (1).

Data on ceftriaxone-resistant Neisseria gonorrhoeae, the bacterium which causes gonorrhoea, covering the first few months of 2025, has also been published (2).

Overall, there were 9,535 diagnoses of early-stage syphilis diagnoses in 2024 compared to 9,375 diagnoses in 2023 – a 2% rise. The overall figure for syphilis, including late-stage syphilis or complications from the infection, increased 5% from 12,456 in 2023 to 13,030 in 2024.

There was a 16% drop in gonorrhoea cases, with 71,802 diagnoses of gonorrhoea in 2024, compared to 85,370 in 2023. The fall has been greatest in young people aged 15 to 24 years where there was a 36% reduction in diagnoses, but it is too soon to conclude whether this trend will continue.

There has been a concerning acceleration in diagnoses of antibiotic-resistant gonorrhoea cases. While most gonorrhoea infections can be treated effectively, certain strains present significant treatment challenges due to antibiotic resistance. Ceftriaxone resistance is particularly concerning as this antibiotic serves as the primary treatment for gonorrhoea infections.

Although numbers remain low, ceftriaxone-resistant gonorrhoea cases are being detected more frequently. There have now been 14 cases reported in the first 5 months of 2025, which is greater than the number of cases reported for the whole of 2024 (13 cases). Six of the 14 cases in 2025 have been extensively drug-resistant cases, which means that they were resistant to ceftriaxone and to second-line treatment options.

Most ceftriaxone resistant cases are associated with travel to or from the Asia-Pacific region, where the prevalence of ceftriaxone resistance is high.

References

1. UKHSA (2025). ‘Sexually transmitted infections and screening for chlamydia in England: 2024 report (https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/sexually-transmitted-infections-stis-

annual-data-tables/sexually-transmitted-infections-and-screening-for-chlamydia-in-england-2024-report)'

2. UKHSA (2025). 'Quarterly report on diagnoses of syphilis, gonorrhoea and ceftriaxone-resistant gonorrhoea in England: provisional data, June 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/sti-quarterly-surveillance-reports-provisional-data/quarterly-report-on-diagnoses-of-syphilis-gonorrhoea-and-ceftriaxone-resistant-gonorrhoea-in-england-provisional-data-june-2025)'

Changes to the national childhood immunisation programme from July 2025

Changes to the national childhood immunisation programme will start to be implemented from 1 July 2025, representing the most significant changes to the programme since 2013, when the highly successful childhood flu and rotavirus vaccination programmes were introduced.

The changes include:

From 1 July 2025

- cessation of routine Hib/MenC offer to those turning 1 year of age
- moving the first pneumococcal conjugate vaccine (PCV13) dose from 12 weeks of age to 16 weeks of age
- bringing forward the second meningococcal group B (MenB) dose from 16 weeks of age to 12 weeks of age
- removal of the dose of monovalent Hepatitis B vaccine given at 12 months of age as part of the selective schedule for babies born to Hepatitis B infected mothers (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-complete-routine-immunisation-schedule/the-complete-routine-immunisation-schedule-from-february-2022#selective-immunisation-programmes)

From 1 January 2026

- introduction of a new routine vaccination appointment at 18 months of age to deliver an additional fourth dose of the 'six-in-one vaccine', to replace the Hib component of Hib/MenC vaccine
- bringing forward the second dose of measles, mumps and rubella (MMR) vaccine (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mmr-for-all-general-leaflet) from 3 years and 4 months of age to 18 months of age, to help to improve vaccine uptake and thereby reducing the likelihood of measles outbreaks

A 5,000 word summary-overview of the changes is available at, 'Childhood schedule changes from 1 July 2025: information for healthcare practitioners (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/childhood-schedule-changes-from-1-july-2025-information-for-healthcare-practitioners/childhood-schedule-changes-from-1-july-2025-information-for-healthcare-practitioners)'.

Key guidance for immunisation professionals and other healthcare practitioners is available as follows:

- 'The UK Immunisation Schedule: the Green Book, chapter 11 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/immunisation-schedule-the-green-book-chapter-11)', which has been updated to take account of the changes to the childhood programme
- explanatory slides, a webinar link and other resources for healthcare practitioners (https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1b-8rdZ37CqnyHpJDvr-hte3DWkdkbo7V)

The changes are the result of a series of recommendations by the Joint Committee on Vaccination and Immunisation (JCVI). In respect of the removal of MenC vaccine from the programme, for example, JCVI advised that this was no longer necessary due to the success of the teenage meningococcal vaccination programme in controlling meningococcal C (MenC) disease across the population.

Final agreement on JCVI's recommendation to introduce a new childhood varicella (chickenpox) vaccination programme (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/childhood-varicella-vaccination-programme-jcvi-advice-14-november-2023/jcvi-statement-on-a-childhood-varicella-chickenpox-vaccination-programme) is pending a decision by Department of Health and Social Care. If agreed, this will result in a further change to the childhood schedule in due course.

Infection reports in this issue

Laboratory confirmed cases of measles, rubella and mumps in England: January to March 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/measles-mumps-and-rubella-lab-confirmed-cases-in-england-2025/laboratory-confirmed-cases-of-measles-rubella-and-mumps-in-england-january-to-march-2025)

Gastrointestinal infections and outbreaks in England: 2023 to 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/gastrointestinal-infections-in-england/gastrointestinal-infections-and-outbreaks-in-england-2023-to-2025)

Carbapenemase-producing Gram-negative organisms in England since October 2020: quarterly update, Q1 2025

(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/carbapenemase-producing-gram-negative-bacteria-laboratory-surveillance/carbapenemase-producing-gram-negative-organisms-in-england-since-october-2020-quarterly-update-q1-2025)

Laboratory reports of Haemophilus influenzae by age group and serotype, England: annual 2024 (and 2023) (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/haemophilus-influenzae-laboratory-reports-by-age-group-and-serotype/laboratory-reports-of-haemophilus-influenzae-by-age-group-and-serotype-england-annual-2024-and-2023)

Tetanus in England: 2023 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/tetanus-in-england-annual-reports/tetanus-in-england-2023)

Creutzfeldt-Jakob disease (CJD) surveillance update 2024 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/creutzfeldt-jakob-disease-cjd-surveillance-update-2024/creutzfeldt-jakob-disease-cjd-surveillance-update-2024)

Vaccine coverage reports

RSV vaccine coverage report in older adults for catch-up cohorts in England: May 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/rsv-immunisation-for-older-adults-and-pregnant-women-vaccine-coverage-in-england/rsv-vaccine-coverage-report-in-older-adults-for-catch-up-cohorts-in-england-may-2025)

RSV maternal vaccination coverage in England: February 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/rsv-immunisation-for-older-adults-and-pregnant-women-vaccine-coverage-in-england/rsv-maternal-vaccination-coverage-in-england-february-2025)

Prenatal pertussis vaccination coverage in England from January to March 2025, and annual coverage for 2024 to 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/pertussis-immunisation-in-pregnancy-vaccine-coverage-estimates-in-england-october-2013-to-march-2014/prenatal-pertussis-vaccination-coverage-in-england-from-january-to-march-2025-and-annual-coverage-for-2024-to-2025)

Quarterly vaccination coverage statistics for children aged up to 5 years in the UK (COVER programme): January to March 2025 (https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/cover-of-vaccination-evaluated-rapidly-cover-programme-2024-to-2025-quarterly-data/quarterly-vaccination-coverage-statistics-for-children-aged-up-to-5-years-in-the-uk-cover-programme-january-to-march-2025)

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